FACING NORTH

OCTOBER 2026

THE KARAKORAM

Wellness & Culinary Journey

A Women-Led Retreat . Hunza & Skardu

11 DAYS | 10 NIGHTS | WOMEN-ONLY | OCT 09-19, 2026

CALM, MINDFUL, AND DEEPLY SENSORY







The Facing North Experience

A Journey for the Senses and the Soul.

In October, the Karakoram mountains are at their most theatrical: golden autumnal light, apple orchards heavy with fruit, the first dusting of snow on the peaks, and a stillness in the crisp air that invites deep reflection. This journey weaves wellness and culinary discovery into a daily rhythm timed perfectly to the mountains and the light.

TRAVELER'S RATING ★★★★½

MOUNTAIN WELLNESS

Daily yoga, breathwork, and guided meditation (no prior experience required).

CALM PACING

No rushing. Every day has room for the soul to catch up with the body.

DEEP CULINARY

Home-hosted meals, cooking classes, and curated dining showcasing authentic Hunza and Balti cuisine.

CULTURAL CONNECTION

Woman-to-woman exchanges and heritage explorations in Asia's most spectacular valleys.

INTRODUCING YOUR FACING NORTH HOSTS



Najma Mehmood

Hi, I'm Najma, a UK-based cultural curator and community host dedicated to sharing the heritage, landscape, and warmth of Pakistan. I have a deep passion for creating restorative, nature-based spaces for women, which has inspired this dedicated Wellness & Culinary Retreat. This journey is crafted as an intimate, slow-paced, and premium experience designed for women seeking intentional travel and self-connection. Through nourishing local cuisine, wellness practices, and quiet exploration, we aim to offer a deeply grounding and transformational space.

INTRODUCING YOUR FACING NORTH HOSTS



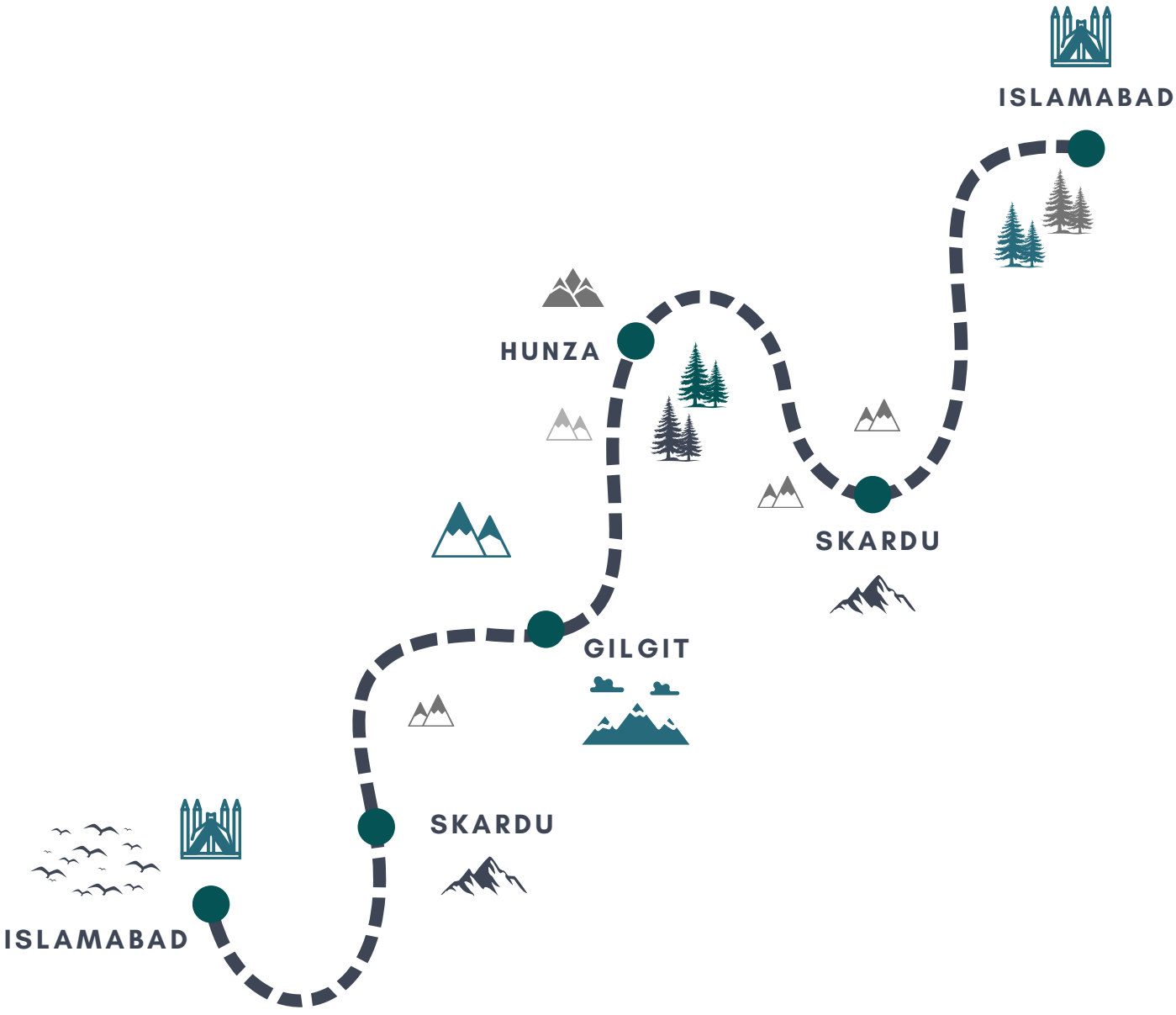
Kehkashan Nadeem

Yoga & Mindfulness Host

Known affectionately as “KK,” Kehkashan is a pioneer in Pakistan’s wellness landscape, recognised for introducing Aerial Yoga to the country. A certified RYT 500-hour advanced teacher trainer with 20+ years of experience in Hatha, Ashtanga, and Vinyasa Flow, she trained extensively in Nepal, Thailand, and Bali. Her mountain sessions blend ancient technique with breathtaking natural settings.

The Route

An expedition mapped for the modern explorer. Watch the landscape transform as we leave the capital behind, winding through lush alpine forests, deep glacial valleys, and the ancient, towering peaks of the North.



DAY 1

Arrival & Intentions

Landing Gently, Setting the Tone in Islamabad

THE RHYTHM

Morning	Arrive at Islamabad Airport where our women-led team will warmly welcome you. Transfer to the serene Ambiance Hotel to rest and freshen up.
Afternoon	Ease into the journey with a gentle city introduction—taking in the stunning architecture of Faisal Mosque, soaking in panoramic views from the Margalla Hills, or enjoying a relaxed, sensory walk through Rawalpindi's bustling old bazaar.
Evening	A curated welcome dinner and the opening of our wellness retreat.

Culinary Focus

Welcome dinner curated by Najma, focusing on the philosophy of "mindful eating" and featuring Islamabad's finest seasonal cuisine.

Wellness Focus

KK leads an "Evening Intentions Circle," a safe space to set personal goals and ground yourself for the journey ahead.

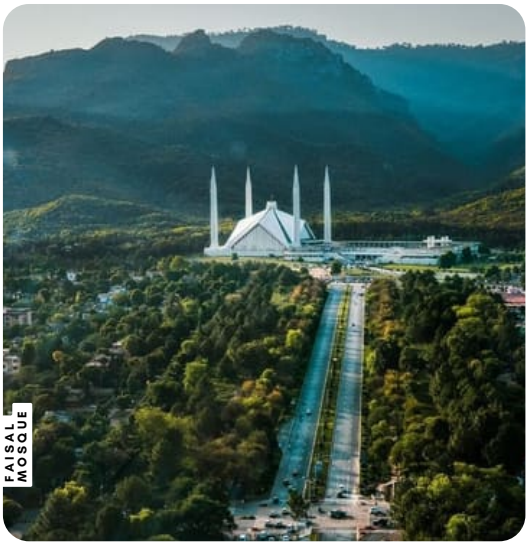


OVERNIGHT

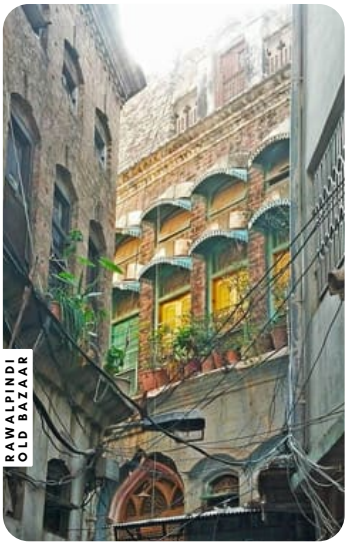
AMBIANCE HOTEL











DAY 2

Flying into the Karakoram

One of the World's Great Short-Haul Flights

THE RHYTHM

Morning	Begin with one of aviation's most extraordinary experiences: a 45-minute flight to Skardu. The aircraft threads its way between Nanga Parbat, the Karakoram, and the Hindu Kush, offering window views usually reserved for mountaineers.
Midday	Upon landing, we embark on a highly scenic drive north toward the Hunza Valley, tracing winding rivers and towering peaks.
Evening	Arrive at the landmark Serena Hunza Hotel as the October afternoon light turns golden across the valley. Settle in with tea on the terrace while Rakaposhi fills the horizon.

Featured Stay
Serena Hunza Hotel

A landmark heritage property perched above the valley with panoramic views of Rakaposhi and Ultar Sar. In October the surrounding poplar trees turn golden, framing the mountains in extraordinary autumn colour.

Wellness Focus

"Air Grounding"—a brief breathwork exercise led by KK upon landing in Skardu, followed by a sunset reflection circle on the Serena terrace in Hunza.



OVERNIGHT
SERENA HUNZA HOTEL









DAY 3

History in Central Hunza

Stories, Homes & Shared Evenings

THE RHYTHM

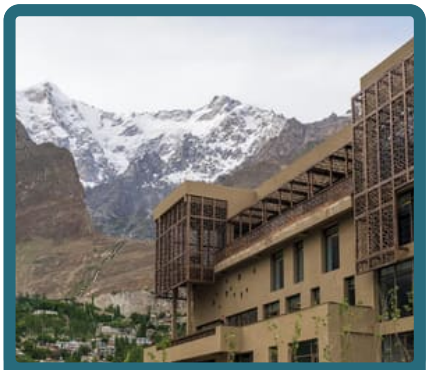
Morning	The day begins with sunrise yoga on the Serena terrace & after a nourishing breakfast, we step back 700 years in time with a visit to Baltit Fort. Your guide brings the royal history of Hunza to life through captivating storytelling rather than standard sightseeing.
Afternoon	Enjoy free time to wander the cobblestone lanes of Karimabad, observing local artisans and autumn colors, before heading to a local family's home for lunch.
Evening	We gather for a private, women-only traditional Hunza musical night, complete with a crackling bonfire and warm chai under a canopy of October stars.

Culinary Focus

Home-hosted recipe exchange. Najma facilitates a genuine culinary conversation with local women, exploring apricot oil, dried mulberry chutney, and hand-rolled chapshoro.

Wellness Focus

"Sunrise Mountain Hatha." The flow is timed perfectly to the moment the valley fills with morning sun and Rakaposhi glows pink.



OVERNIGHT

SERENA HUNZA HOTEL





SERENA HUNZA HOTEL



HUNZA VALLEY



BALTIT FORT

DAY 4

The Mountain Kitchen & Spa

The Most Immersive Day of the Hunza Chapter

THE RHYTHM

Morning	Visit Altit Fort and its surrounding village. Three centuries older than Baltit and perched above the river gorge, this is a quieter heritage site. We then venture into the Hopar Valley, walking among terraced orchards where apple and apricot trees burst with their autumn harvest.
Midday	Head to a local family setting for an immersive, hands-on cooking demonstration.
Evening	The late afternoon and evening are deliberately kept open and unstructured—a rare space to simply sit, breathe, and exist alongside the mountains.

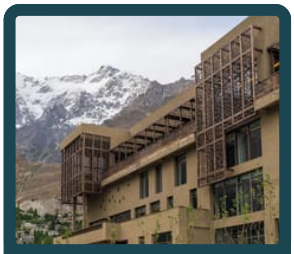
Complimentary Experience

SERENA SPA

Exclusively arranged for the group as part of this itinerary, a signature wellness session within a Time Magazine World's Greatest Places property. Set at the foot of the Karakoram range, the Serena Spa offers a deeply restorative counterpoint to the days of exploration, perfectly complementing Kehkashan's wellness programme.

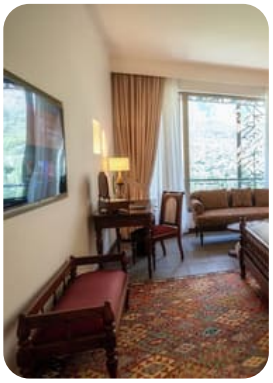
Culinary Focus

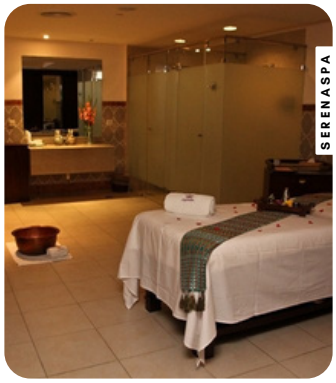
Mountain Kitchen: hands-on Hunza cooking session with our local host seasonal produce, ancient recipes.



OVERNIGHT

SERENA HUNZA HOTEL

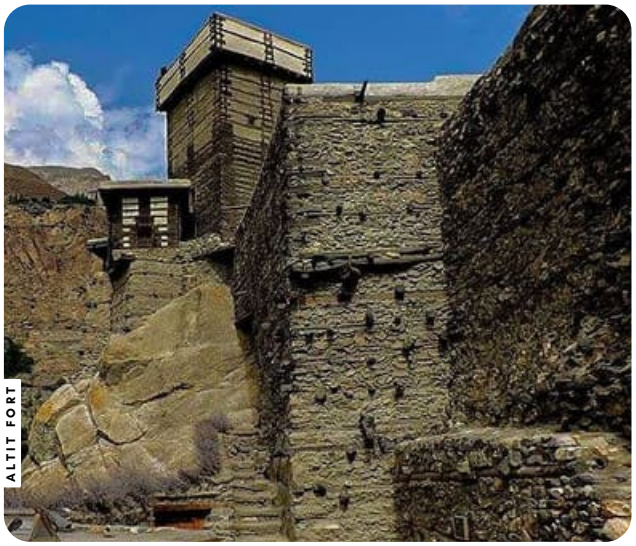




SERENASPA



HOPAR VALLEY



ALTIT FORT

DAY 5

Lakes, Cones & Women's Craft

The Turquoise Waters of Upper Hunza

THE RHYTHM

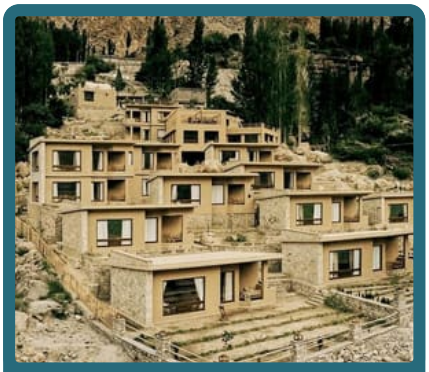
Morning	We journey into Upper Hunza's dramatic glacial scenery. Take a serene boat ride on Attabad Lake, its turquoise waters contrasting against ochre cliffs, before driving toward the iconic Passu Cones—cathedral-like granite spires.
Midday	Visit a women-led textile cooperative, directly supporting local artisans who handweave traditional Wakhi carpets and intricate embroidered shawls.
Evening	Arrive at your lakeside accommodation to unwind as the October light fades over the water.

Culinary Focus

Najma leads a conversation at the cooperative regarding the intersection of food economics and ancient textile traditions in Upper Hunza.

Wellness Focus

An open-sky meditation facing the Passu Cones, followed by a sunset lakeside yoga sequence at Zen by the Lake.



OVERNIGHT

ZEN BY THE LAKE









DAY 6

A Moving Meditation

Through the Mountains to Gilgit

THE RHYTHM

Morning	The day opens with a calm lakeside walk before we begin our drive south. We detour through the lush village of Minapin, taking a short, thrilling jeep ride to an elevated viewpoint for sweeping panoramas of Diran Peak and Rakaposhi.
Midday	Enjoy a rich, community-rooted lunch in Minapin before continuing the drive.
Evening	Arrive in Gilgit. Settle into the hotel and enjoy a leisurely riverside stroll or browse the old bazaar for local handicrafts.

Culinary Focus

Curated lunch at Osho Thang the distinct flavours of Gilgiti mountain cuisine introduced by the local host.

Wellness Focus

KK frames the drive itself as a "Moving Meditation," encouraging periods of mindful silence and observation as the landscapes shift.



OVERNIGHT

RAMADA GILGIT HOTEL





SERENA GILGIT HOTEL



MINAPIN



DIRAN PEAK

DAY 7

Into Baltistan

Changing Valleys and Glacial Lakes

THE RHYTHM

Morning	Trace the legendary Indus River through the geological heart of Asia. The landscape dramatically shifts from the lush greens of Hunza into the stark, mineral-rich ochres and silvers of Baltistan.
Midday	Pause at Upper Kachura Lake for a short, easy walk through the forest to reach the hidden glacial waters, followed by a peaceful lunch near Lower Kachura Lake.
Evening	Arrive at Hashupi Resort in Skardu. The evening is yours to rest, wander the gardens, and settle into the Balti pace of life.

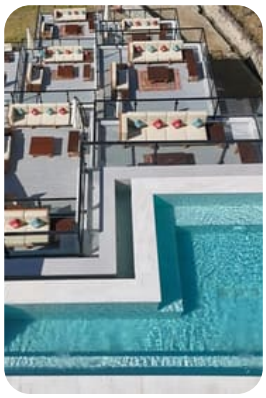
Wellness Focus

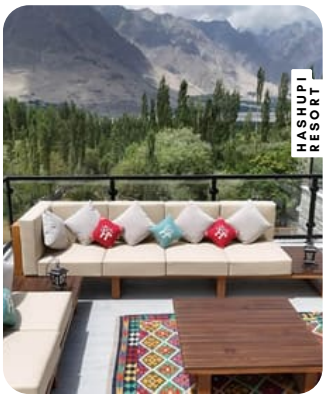
Morning breathwork before departing Gilgit, focusing on releasing travel fatigue and preparing the body for the high altitude of Skardu.



OVERNIGHT

HASHUPI RESORT









DAY 8

Heritage & High Altitudes

Shigar Fort to the Cold Desert

THE RHYTHM

Morning	Explore Shigar Fort, a 17th-century Balti Raja's residence lovingly restored by the Aga Khan Trust. Wander through carved wooden chambers and river-facing courtyard gardens.
Midday	After a fort lunch, transition to the surreal Katpana Cold Desert to witness the extraordinary contrast of fine sand dunes rolling directly against 8,000-meter glaciated peaks.
Evening	Return to Hashupi Resort as the sun sets behind the mountains for our evening bonfire.

Culinary Focus

Lunch at Shigar Fort's atmospheric courtyard. Later, Najma presents the distinctive flavors of Skardu's food heritage during a curated Balti dinner.

Wellness Focus

Evening Storytelling Circle. KK guides a profound group reflection by the bonfire, touching on vulnerability and the journey so far.



OVERNIGHT

HASHUPI RESORT







DAY 9

The Balti Kitchen

The Most Complete Day in Skardu

THE RHYTHM

Morning	Ascend to Kharpocho, the ancient Balti fortification. Unpack the fort's rich Silk Road history while taking in unparalleled panoramic views across the Skardu basin and the winding Indus River.
Midday	Head to a local Skardu home for deep cultural and culinary immersion, learning the secrets of Baltistan's historic recipes.
Evening	Celebrate the culmination of your time in the North with our final mountain feast.

Culinary Focus

The "Balti Kitchen" hands-on cooking class. Learn to cook marzan, chhurpe cheese, and barley bread baked on a mountain hearth. Evening brings a curated Farewell Skardu Feast.

Wellness Focus

Sunrise yoga at Hashupi Resort as the morning sun hits the fort on the ridge above.



OVERNIGHT

HASHUPI RESORT

ALL MEALS INCLUDED – FULL BOARD





KHARPOCHO



GLIGIT

DAY 10

A Shift in Rhythm

From the Mountains to the Old City

THE RHYTHM

Morning	A morning flight carries the group from the silence of Baltistan back into the capital. And checking in to the Ambiance Hotel followed with a short rest
Midday	Visit to Andhraun Rawalpindi, the living, breathing old city of Rawalpindi with its centuries old bazaars, spice markets, Shah Faisal Mosque views, and the extraordinary sensory energy that only an ancient South Asian marketplace can offer.
Evening	As the sun sets over the Margalla Hills, the group makes their way to Monal Restaurant, Islamabad's most celebrated dining destination.

Monal Restaurant

Set on the Margalla Hills overlooking all of Islamabad, Monal is Pakistan's most famous destination restaurant — a fitting final evening as the mountains frame the city one last time. Outdoor terrace seating is arranged for the group. The farewell dinner is included in the package.



OVERNIGHT

AMBIANCE HOTEL

ALL MEALS INCLUDED – FULL BOARD







DAY 11

Farewell To Pakistan

The Journey Within Continues

THE RHYTHM

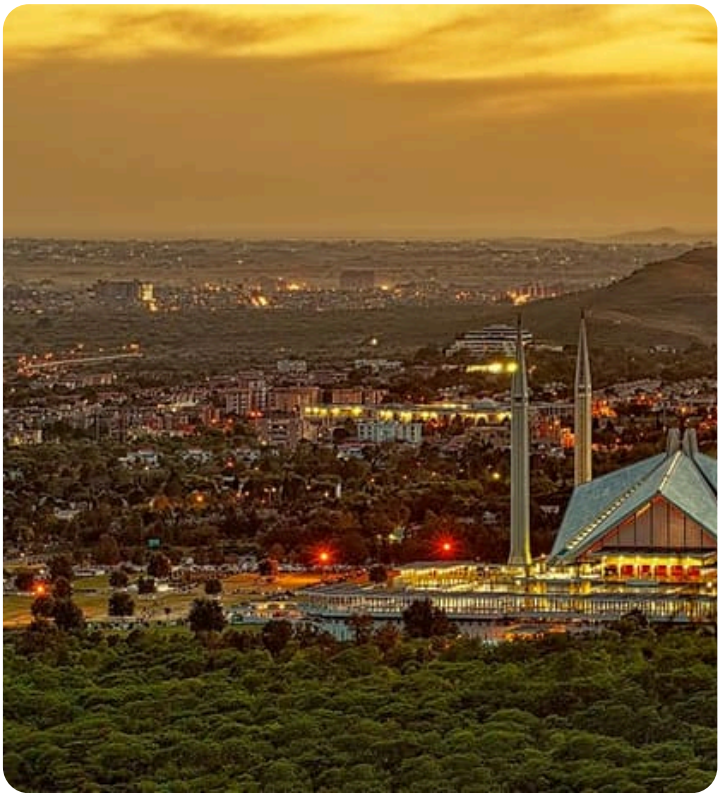
Morning	Our journey concludes with a leisurely, unhurried final breakfast together at the hotel. It's a morning for sharing memories and savoring the bonds forged over the past ten days.
Midday	After our final closing sessions, guests will check out and take their individual transfers to Lahore Airport (LHE), carrying the spirit of the mountains home with them.

Wellness Focus

KK leads the "Closing Circle"—a guided meditation integrating the people, the mountains, and the journey within.

NOTE

Airport drop-off transfers are not included. Your hotel can arrange a taxi or ride-share on request. International





Inclusions & Exclusions

WHAT'S INCLUDED

ACCOMMODATIONS

10 nights in boutique / heritage lodges

- *Ambiance Islamabad Hotel (1 night)*
- *Serena Hunza Hotel (3 nights)*
- *Zen by the Lake (1 night)*
- *Serena Gilgit Hotel (1 night)*
- *Hashupi Resort, Skardu (3 nights)*
- *Ambiance Hotel, Lahore (2 nights)*

YOGA

All yoga, mindfulness & meditation sessions led by Kehkashan Nadeem

$

All entry fees, permits & site charges

DOMESTIC FLIGHTS

RETURN
Islamabad-Skardu

SERENA SPA

Complimentary Serena Spa Experience at Serena Hunza Hotel

Private AC Coaster & 4×4 jeeps for all transfers

MEALS

All Meals Included

WORKSHOPS

All culinary workshops & demonstrations by Najma Qizilbash

TIPS

All drivers, local guides, hotel staff & restaurants

WHAT'S NOT INCLUDED

- ✘ International flights to/from Pakistan
- ✘ Visa fees (e-visa usually applied online)
- ✘ Travel insurance (mandatory; must cover high altitude)
- ✘ Lunches on designated free days
- ✘ Personal expenses, shopping & souvenirs
- ✘ Airport drop-off on Day 11 (departure transfer)
- ✘ Personal tip for tour leader (at guest's discretion)



Package cost (GBP)

Group Size	DOUBLE OCCUPANCY (NET)	SINGLE OCCUPANCY (NET)
10-14 Pax	GBP 1,950	GBP. 2,330

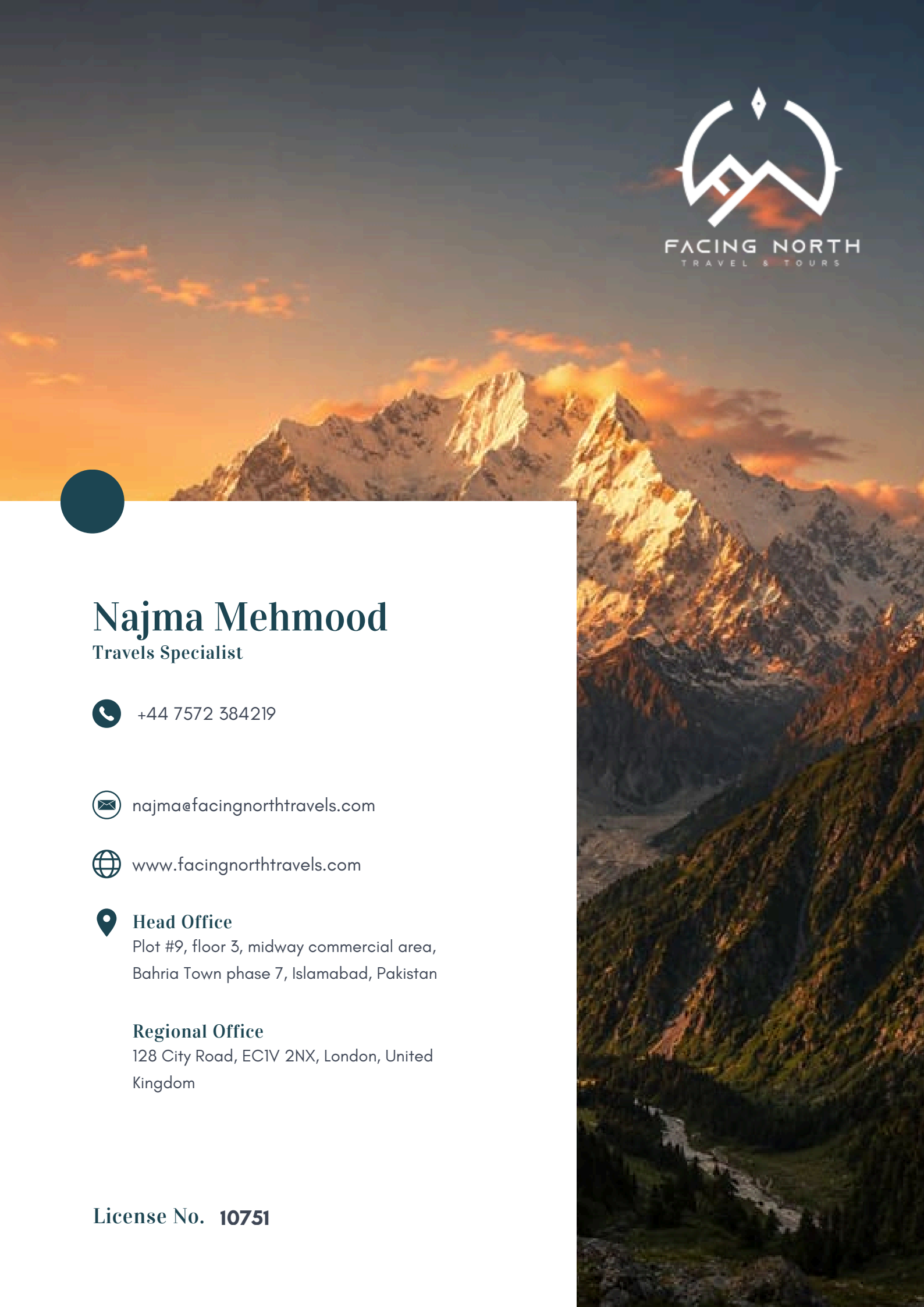
Note: All prices mentioned above are per person

Safety, Comfort & Female Support Framework

- **The "Host-Ally" Model:** Kehkashan and Najma provide a dual layer of support, facilitating both your internal wellness journey and your physical experience of the mountains.
- **Cultural Shielding:** Being a female-only group allows for “Zenana” (private female space) access, where guests can interact intimately with local women away from the male gaze.
- **Physical Inclusivity:** All wellness sessions and yoga are "no-pressure" zones, adaptable to individual energy levels and the local altitude.
- **Safe Mobility:** We use vetted, female-friendly vehicles and provide pre-briefed female-centric precautions to ensure guests feel respected and comfortable throughout.

What to Carry

Wellness	Travel yoga mat, meditation cushion, and personal journal for reflection.
Clothing	Layered warm clothing: base layers, fleece, and a windbreaker for mountain conditions.
Modest Attire	Loose cotton tunics covering the hips and a large dupatta for mosques and village visits.
Footwear	Broken-in walking shoes for village walks; slip-on sandals for mosques and wellness sessions.
Documents	At least 10 photocopies of passport and visa for regional checkpoints.



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TRAVEL & TOURS

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